

Lost Property

a story, in minutes

MINUTES OF THE COMMISSION ON LOST PROPERTY

Station of Gorna Ohrana · meeting the forty-first · present: the Chair, the Archivist, the Advocate, the Widow Koleva, the Stationmaster · minutes by the undersigned

1. The Commission meets, by tradition, at the arrival of the 17:40, that being the train that produces its work. The 17:40 was eleven minutes late. The Advocate raised the question whether a meeting convened upon an arrival has convened if nothing has arrived. The Chair ruled that the meeting had convened and the world was late. So minuted.

The previous taker of minutes held this post thirty-one years. His pen was in the drawer and writes well.

2. Item: one umbrella, black, men's, second-class carriage, the 3rd inst. The Archivist reported provenance: maker's stamp of a workshop in Ruse; wear on the ferrule indicating a man who walks with a lean; third rib mended in red thread, economically, by someone with a large spool of red. He requested the item be held pending completion of its history. The Chair asked when a history completes. The Archivist took the question under review.

The Advocate objected that the item is not an umbrella. An umbrella is an instrument for keeping off rain; this one, the spring being broken, keeps off nothing; it is a walking stick with ambitions, and belongs on another schedule. Motion to reschedule failed for want of a second. The Advocate moved to second it himself; ruled out of order; requested the ruling in writing; received it; said it would lose on appeal.

The Widow Koleva examined the item and said it was waiting for somebody, but nobody here.

Held. Shelf two.

3. Item: one jar of buttons. The Stationmaster moved release to anyone at all, citing a fifth of a shelf-meter. The Widow Koleva took three buttons. The Advocate asked whether the jar less three buttons remains the jar of the 14th or becomes a successor jar. Item adjourned.

4. Item: one glove, child's, left. Held, the right being presumably in service.

5. No further business. The 17:40 came in during item three. Nobody got down.

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Meeting the forty-second.

6. Item: one dog, yellow, medium, found asleep in the lamp room. The dog attended, there being no provision for excluding it. The Archivist reported that dogs carry no maker's stamp. The Advocate submitted that the dog cannot be lost property, property being a thing, and the dog — as demonstrated by its conduct during his submission — being a person of views; he moved to strike the item. The Widow Koleva said the dog had already chosen and declined to say whom. Motion to remand the dog to the pound failed with no votes in favor, including the mover's. The Stationmaster observed that some motions are brought in order to be seen failing.

The dog attends meetings now. It sits by the Stationmaster, who feeds it from his coat.

7. Item: one ring of keys, seven, no fob. The Advocate noted for the record that the keys are not lost; the keys are found, and in good standing; it is seven doors that are lost, and the Commission's jurisdiction over doors has not been established. Held on behalf of the doors.

The undersigned's father kept his keys on a nail by the kitchen window. They are still there.

8. Item: one hat, brown. Claimed Tuesday by the schoolmaster. Struck.

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Meeting the forty-third.

9. Item: one letter, sealed, stamped, unaddressed, found in the lining of a donated coat. One hour and forty minutes.

The Stationmaster moved to open it: an unaddressed letter is undeliverable, and an unopened one is a permanent tenth of a shelf-meter. The Archivist opposed; the letter could be traced through the coat, the coat through its buttons, the buttons — the Chair thanked the Archivist. The Widow Koleva held the letter flat

between her hands for some time and said it was still warm. It has been in a coat lining for years, the Stationmaster said. Yes, she said.

The Advocate: a letter is not finished by writing but by arriving. An unaddressed letter is therefore unfinished — the address is its last sentence — and the Commission holds not lost property but an interrupted intention, for which there is no schedule and no shelf. He added that most people carry several, in the lining, and sat down.

Ruled: held unopened, in the drawer, not on the shelf. No vote was taken.

10. Item: one pocket-knife. Held. Item: one music score, partial. Held. Item: one saint's-day card, signed "M." Held. The Stationmaster asked to have his remarks on the shelf situation entered; they were entered; they are in the annex.

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Meeting the forty-fourth.

11. Item: one pair of reading spectacles, wire, mended at the bridge with red thread, found in the drawer of this desk.

Brought forward by the undersigned, who has no standing to bring items. The Chair suspended the regulation before the request was finished.

The Archivist gave provenance: complete. First of his career, he said, and asked that no note be made of anything further. The Advocate held that the spectacles were at no time lost, their location having been known throughout, and are not property, the dead not owning things but being survived by them; he undertook to draft the appropriate schedule, there being none. The Widow Koleva said they had chosen already and had merely been waiting for the chooser to look in the drawer; also that the wire wants bending at the left temple; also that red thread holds. The Stationmaster put wood on the stove and said nothing, and did not measure anything.

Ruled: found. Released to the successor.

12. These minutes were read and approved, with one amendment from the Chair: that the word *father*, where it appears above, stand.

Next meeting at the 17:40.